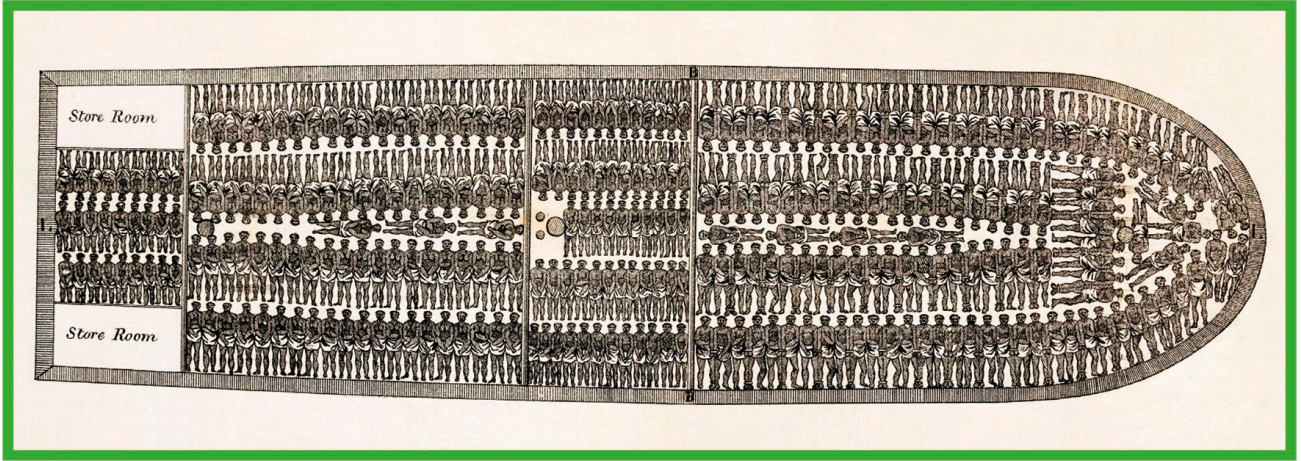


See also: Slave codes 98–101 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117 ■ The US Supreme Court and judicial review 124–129 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The Civil Rights Act 248–253



escaped. He was recaptured and put on a boat bound for Jamaica to be resold. Abolitionist Granville Sharp took up his case and Lord Mansfield, the lord chief justice, issued a writ of *habeas corpus* (an order to bring a person under arrest before a judge or court to decide whether the detention is lawful). Somerset duly appeared before the Court of King's Bench.

Lord Mansfield ruled in 1772 that, although slavery was allowed in the colonies, a slave in England

was subject to English law. As no English law permitted Somerset's recapture and forcible shipping to Jamaica, he had to be freed. The judge tried to make a ruling that freed Somerset without setting a precedent, but the case was a watershed moment in the abolitionist movement. It was widely seen as outlawing slavery in Britain, allowing other slaves to plead for their own freedom.

In Britain, growing opposition to the slave trade was fueled in part by atrocities such as the *Zong* massacre. In 1781, due to severe overcrowding on the slave ship *Zong*, Captain Luke Collingwood commanded 132 sick slaves be thrown overboard. (If any slaves died of sickness, insurers would not pay compensation, but would do so if the slaves had been killed to safeguard the ship.) In law, slaves were viewed as commodities rather than people, so it was treated

The slave ship *Brookes* became notorious in 1788, when abolitionists published an engraving of the appalling yet legal conditions onboard, including its cramped lower deck.

as a disputed insurance claim rather than as mass murder. Such rank injustice brought many more people to the abolitionist cause.

Abolitionist campaigns

In 1787, 12 activists founded the Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade at a printing shop in London. They included Thomas Clarkson, who had recently published an influential essay condemning slavery. The society's many women supporters—10 percent of its subscribers in the first year were women—included prominent abolitionists Quaker poet Mary Birkett Card, evangelist Hannah More, and feminist philosopher Mary Wollstonecraft.

To inform popular opinion on the arguments against slavery, the society's network of campaigners produced pamphlets, hosted talks, and secured signatures on petitions. The goal was abolition »



A replica of *Zong*, the ship from which slaves were thrown to ease overcrowding, took part in events in London in 2007 to mark 200 years since the Abolition of the Slave Trade Act.